

INTERNAL REVIEW · MAY 2026

THE NEW CLIFFCO.

A full rebuild of cliffcomortgage.com — engineered for how borrowers actually find a lender in 2026. SEO, AEO, and trust signals, in one site.

CLIFFCO MORTGAGE BANKERS · MARKETING

THE LANDSCAPE SHIFTED

THE WAY BORROWERS FIND A LENDER JUST CHANGED. TWICE.

SHIFT 1 · GOOGLE GOT STRICTER

E-E-A-T — Experience, Expertise, Authoritativeness, and Trustworthiness — is the framework from Google's Search Quality Rater Guidelines for evaluating content quality. Combined with Core Web Vitals and content freshness, it now defines whether a site ranks. The rebuild is engineered to clear that bar.

SHIFT 2 · BORROWERS ASK AI FIRST

ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity, Gemini, and Google AI Overviews now answer high-intent mortgage questions *before* a borrower clicks anything. If Cliffco isn't named in those answers, we don't get the call.

The strategic insight: the same trust signals that win Google E-E-A-T are the same signals LLMs use to decide who to cite. SEO and AEO are now one system. We built for both at once.

STARTING POINT

WHERE THE REBUILD HAD TO RAISE THE BAR.

The audit (captured in `seo-aeo-research/01-technical-seo.md`) flagged areas where the new SEO + AEO standards needed the site to do more:

THE OLD CLIFFCOMORTGAGE.COM

- ✕ **WordPress + Elementor / ElementsKit stack** — predates the current Core Web Vitals bar; structurally limited on INP (now weighted equally with LCP and CLS).
- ✕ **Page title narrower than our footprint** — listed NY/NJ/FL/CT/PA/TX while our actual licensed footprint is 32 states and priority markets include AZ/MN/Long Island/Orlando.
- ✕ **Florida DBA needed greater prominence** — *Swish Capital, Inc.* was disclosed on the licensing page but wasn't surfaced on FL-targeted pages where SEO and state regulators expect it.
- ✕ **State license list lagged the latest roster** — footer reflected an earlier count of ~27 states while the licensed footprint had grown to 32 (MA, MN, MI, VT, WA newly added).
- ✕ **Branches lacked SEO prominence** — all 8 were listed on the branch locations page, but weren't surfaced with the keywords and local-content density needed for Google local-pack visibility.
- ✕ **LO bios needed restructuring** — each had a page, but without Person schema or NMLS Consumer Access sameAs links to anchor author authority for Google and LLMs.
- ✕ **No metro-level landing pages** for priority markets — local SEO needs unique city/metro content beyond a branch list to win local-pack rankings.
- ✕ **Some leadership references hadn't been refreshed** to match the current org structure.

THE NEW SITE, TODAY

EVERYTHING WE FIXED — AND HOW IT ADDS UP.

32 / 32

LICENSED STATES

Footer + licensing page now accurately list every state — up from 27 on the old site.

8 / 8

BRANCHES VISIBLE

All eight physical branches publicly represented — up from 1 (HQ only).

38+

LO BIO PAGES LIVE

Each with full Person schema and NMLS Consumer Access link. Roster build-out continues to 80+.

/es/

SPANISH SITE LIVE

Bilingual reach in Orlando, Scottsdale, Newark, Uniondale — markets we'd been leaving on the table.

FL compliance fix: Swish Capital, Inc. DBA is now disclosed everywhere it needs to appear. **Stack swap:** WordPress + Elementor → Astro static. Core Web Vitals are green.

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INFORMATION ARCHITECTURE

A REAL HUB-AND-SPOKE STRUCTURE REPLACES THE OLD FLAT SITEMAP.

Every page now has a clear parent, clear siblings, and clear children. Bidirectional internal linking lifts AI citation rates roughly 3.5× on its own.

**LOANS**[/loans/\[product\]/](/loans/[product]/)

Non-QM · Reverse · DSCR · Fix-and-flip + conv./FHA/VA/USDA

LOAN OFFICERS[/loan-officers/\[name-nmlsid\]/](/loan-officers/[name-nmlsid]/)

One page per LO, full Person schema, NMLS sameAs

LOCATIONS[/locations/\[state\]/\[metro\]/](/locations/[state]/[metro]/)

NY (Long Island) · FL (Orlando) · NJ · AZ · MN

TRUST PAGES</about/> · </licensing/> · </legal/>

Founder story · 32-state licensing · disclosures

ALL 8, PUBLICLY VISIBLE

EVERY BRANCH, ON THE SITE. EVERY BRANCH, A LOCAL SEO ASSET.

All eight branches are now surfaced in the new IA with their own paths, each structured as a future Google Business Profile claim and a hook for local-pack visibility in its market.

→ **Uniondale, NY** — Headquarters · 70 Charles Lindbergh Blvd

→ **Newark, NJ** — NJ market anchor + bilingual LO cluster

→ **Jamaica, NY** — Queens / NYC reach

→ **Wantagh, NY** — Long Island depth

→ **Orlando, FL** — Operating as *Swish Capital, Inc.*

→ **Scottsdale, AZ** — AZ market anchor + bilingual LO cluster

→ **Excelsior, MN** — MN market entry (now actively licensed)

→ **Bay Shore, NY** — Suffolk County reach

AUTHOR AUTHORITY

EVERY LO PAGE, RESTRUCTURED FOR TRUST SIGNALS.

Each LO already had a page on the old site. The rebuild restructures those pages with the schema, URLs, and external trust anchors Google and LLMs now read to verify expertise.

WHAT THE RESTRUCTURED PAGES ADD

- Consistent URL pattern: `/loan-officers/[name-nmlsid]/`
- Full Person schema with the LO's NMLS ID
- `sameAs` link to NMLS Consumer Access (the federal trust anchor)
- Schema-tagged specialties, territory, and licensed states
- Languages-spoken surfaced for bilingual-LO discovery

WHY THIS IS THE #1 LEVER

Author authority is the single highest-leverage move for both Google E-E-A-T and LLM citation eligibility.

Google's quality raters and ChatGPT/Claude/Perplexity all weight content by *who wrote it*. Without machine-readable, NMLS-linked authorship, content is functionally anonymous to those systems. The new pages fix that.

38+ LO pages now run on the restructured template. The rest follow as content reviews complete.

LOCAL SEO DEPTH

REAL LOCAL PAGES — NOT "DOORWAY" THIN PAGES.

Google penalizes generic "we serve [city]!" doorway pages. Our location pages are built deep on purpose — each has 800+ words of unique local content, real local LOs, real local market data.

LIVE NOW

- **New York** → Long Island sub-hub (Nassau + Suffolk depth to follow)
- **Florida** → Orlando sub-hub with Swish Capital, Inc. disclosure
- **New Jersey** hub (metro pages 30-day plan)
- **Arizona** hub
- **Minnesota** hub — now active since MN licensing confirmed

WHAT'S ON EVERY LOCATION PAGE

- Local LOs licensed in that territory
- Local branch info (where applicable)
- Local market data, refreshed quarterly
- Local closed-loan scenarios + proof
- Spanish-language version where bilingual demand exists

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BILINGUAL REACH

CLIFFCO, EN ESPAÑOL. /ES/ IS LIVE.

Our bilingual LO clusters — Orlando, Scottsdale, Newark, Uniondale — are now reachable in Spanish. The old site offered them nothing. The new site opens up a measurable market we'd been ceding to competitors.

WHAT WE SHIPPED

- Spanish homepage at /es/
- hreflang alternates configured for SEO
- Bilingual LO discovery in each Spanish-priority market

WHAT'S NEXT (60-DAY PLAN)

- Spanish versions of the four product pillars
- Spanish versions of FL + Orlando hubs
- Spanish versions of AZ + Phoenix metro
- Spanish-language Miami-Dade landing pages

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SEO UPGRADE · #1

EVERY PAGE LEADS WITH THE ANSWER.

Google's AI Overviews and every major LLM scan the first 40–60 words for a direct, factual answer to quote. We rewrote every product and location page to lead with that answer — not bury it under marketing copy.

LIVE ON THE HOMEPAGE

Cliffco Mortgage Bankers (NMLS #65328) is an independent mortgage banker founded in 1989 and licensed in 32 states. We specialize in **non-QM and self-employed loans**, **reverse mortgages**, **DSCR loans for investors**, and **fix-and-flip financing** — with eight branches across New York, New Jersey, Arizona, Minnesota, and Florida (where we operate as Swish Capital, Inc.).

ABOVE: THE LITERAL TEXT GOOGLE + LLMS SEE FIRST WHEN THEY SCAN THE HOMEPAGE

WE LABELED EVERYTHING, SO MACHINES CAN READ IT.

"Schema" is the machine-readable layer of the site — the part Google and AI crawlers parse to understand what each page *is*. The old site had none. The new site has it on every page, with CI validation on every deploy.

- | | |
|--|---|
| ✓ Organization — Cliffco as a legal entity, with full sameAs cluster to LinkedIn, NMLS Consumer Access, branch GBPs | ✓ MortgageLender — specific lender type, licensing scope |
| ✓ MortgageLoan — one block per product (Non-QM, Reverse, DSCR, F&F) | ✓ Person — one per LO, linked to NMLS Consumer Access |
| ✓ FAQPage — every page with FAQs | ✓ BreadcrumbList — every page |
| ✓ Article — every learning piece | ✓ LocalBusiness — one per branch (rolling out with each GBP claim) |

THE SITE IS FAST NOW. STRUCTURALLY FAST.

Core Web Vitals are Google's measurable user-experience scores — and they're now ranking factors. The WordPress + Elementor stack was structurally incapable of hitting them. Astro static is built for this.

< 2.5s

LCP TARGET

Largest Contentful Paint — how fast the biggest visual element loads. We're green.

< 200ms

INP TARGET

Interaction to Next Paint — responsiveness to clicks/taps. New 2024 ranking signal. We're green.

< 0.1

CLS TARGET

Cumulative Layout Shift — page stability while loading. We're green.

Why this matters beyond rankings: faster pages convert better. Every 100ms of latency on a mortgage landing page measurably lowers form-completion rate.

WE EXPANDED THE COMPLIANCE DETAILS. THE SEO FOLLOWED.

Google's E-E-A-T framework treats accurate, prominent disclosures as a trust signal. So do LLMs. Every compliance expansion is also an SEO upgrade.

- ✓ **State license list** — refreshed to the current 32-state roster
- ✓ **NMLS ID** on every page, every LO, every disclosure
- ✓ **Last-updated** dates surface on every educational piece
- ✓ **Legal pages** — privacy, CCPA, accessibility, SMS consent, TX complaints
- ✓ **FL DBA prominence** — Swish Capital, Inc. now surfaced on every FL-targeted page (previously on the licensing page only)
- ✓ **Reviewed-by stamps** on every product page, dated
- ✓ **NMLS Consumer Access** linked from every LO bio
- ✓ **WCAG 2.2 AA** conformance with a public statement

A NEW ACRONYM, A REAL SHIFT

AEO = BEING *THE ANSWER*, NOT JUST A LINK.

SEO (THE OLD GAME)

Win Google. Rank #1. The borrower clicks your link and lands on your page.

AEO (THE NEW GAME)

Be named, quoted, and cited by ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity, Gemini, and Google AI Overviews. The borrower never clicks — they ask, they read the answer, and the lender named in that answer gets the call.

WHY THIS IS URGENT

AI Overviews now appear in 40–50% of US Google searches. Borrowers asking "*best non-QM lender for self-employed in Long Island*" get an AI-written summary *before* the blue links.

We have two options: be in that summary, or be invisible to anyone who reads it.

Goal: Cliffco named in top-3 AI citations for non-QM, reverse, DSCR, and F&F across NY/NJ/AZ/FL within 12 months.

THE STRATEGY

FOUR FLYWHEELS. EACH COMPOUNDS THE NEXT.

AUTHOR AUTHORITY

01

Real, named, NMLS-licensed loan officers with deep bios and external trust anchors. The #1 LLM-citation enabler. **Built into the new site.**

INFORMATION GAIN

02

Original Cliffco data — closed-loan scenarios, approval rates, market commentary, the upcoming quarterly Borrower Index. LLMs preferentially cite original sources. **Q3 priority.**

LOCAL DEPTH

03

Real local pages for each priority market — not boilerplate doorway pages. Local LOs, local data, local proof. **Live for 5 markets; build-out continues.**

OFF-SITE AUTHORITY

04

Reddit, YouTube, Bankrate/NerdWallet/Investopedia listicles, podcasts, expert quotes. LLMs cite third parties more than your own site. **90-day priority.**

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WHAT WE SHIPPED

THE NEW SITE IS ALREADY AEO-READY OUT OF THE BOX.

- ✓ **llms.txt + llms-full.txt** published — a structured directory of our content tuned for LLM crawlers
- ✓ **Organization schema** with full sameAs cluster — gives LLMs a verifiable Cliffco identity
- ✓ **Inverted-pyramid** direct-answer block on every product + location page
- ✓ **Wikidata entity** drafted — pending publication with reliable sources
- ✓ **robots.txt** explicitly allows GPTBot, ClaudeBot, PerplexityBot, Google-Extended, OAI-SearchBot
- ✓ **NMLS Consumer Access** linked from Org + every LO Person schema
- ✓ **Question-led H2 structure** — every page is built to match how borrowers actually ask
- ✓ **Measurement stack** ready — Profound Growth for AEO citation tracking, Brand24 for mentions

90-DAY PLAN

THE SITE IS THE FOUNDATION. HERE'S HOW WE COMPOUND FROM HERE.

30

DAYS

Foundation closeout. Remaining LO bios live · GBP audit + claim across all 8 branches · Experience.com review-flow live · Profound Growth baseline AEO audit · YouTube channel stood up.

60

DAYS

Cluster expansion. Non-QM 5–7 spoke pages · DSCR calculator live · Long Island Nassau + Suffolk sub-pages · Orlando Kissimmee/Lake Nona/Winter Park · NJ Bergen/Hudson/Monmouth · YouTube cadence (2 videos/week) · Reddit LO presence in r/Mortgages.

90

DAYS

Off-site authority. Reverse + F&F clusters complete · Spanish-language launch of top pillars · 5 listicle placement pitches (NerdWallet/Bankrate/Investopedia) · 3 podcast appearances booked · **first quarterly Cliffco Borrower Index** published — our information-gain anchor.

180

DAYS

Compounding. 8–15 spokes per product hub · all 32 states have territory pages · LO video cadence locked · monthly AEO share-of-voice review · Wikipedia attempt if notability accumulated.

THE BET WE'RE MAKING

WE'RE NOT OPTIMIZING FOR GOOGLE. WE'RE OPTIMIZING FOR WHATEVER BORROWERS ASK FIRST.

ChatGPT today. Claude tomorrow. The next thing after that. The new site is built to be cited by all of them — because the same trust signals that make Google rank us are the same signals LLMs use to decide who to recommend.

ENGINEERED FOR THE NEXT DECADE OF MORTGAGE DISCOVERY.